task force—but his health problems would become more pronounced in the hot and humid climate of Cuba, while his ability to command respect and keep his subordinates in line would be challenged.[15]

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GENERAL PLIEV, WHOSE LAST NAME WAS CHANGED FOR CONSPIRACY reasons to Pavlov, and his deputies flew to Havana on July 10 on board a Tupolev 114, the largest and fastest airplane of its time—the same model that Khrushchev had used to fly to the United States in the fall of 1959. They joined a delegation led by the head of the Soviet Civic Aviation Administration, Yevgenii Loginov, posing as Soviet airplane experts. Their flight to Havana was special—the very first Soviet flight to the island, intended as a test run to check the feasibility of regular passenger flights between Moscow and Havana.

The plane had to make a refueling stop, and the new Soviet satellite of Guinea on the west coast of Africa was its first destination. The Soviets had built a new airport in the capital, Conakry, partly as a component of an assistance program and partly to accommodate their own need for transatlantic flights. Accordingly, Pliev and his group first headed for Conakry, where they witnessed the festive opening of the Soviet-built airport, with Loginov presiding, and then continued to Havana, where they were greeted by crowds celebrating the arrival of the first flight from Moscow.[16]

The next airplane for Havana left Moscow on July 18. On board, apart from Pliev's personal doctor, was a group of officers from Statsenko's division in Ukraine. They had been called to Moscow a month earlier, on June 18, and held meetings with Biriuzov, Tolubko, and Gribkov. They had to prepare for their first task—surveying locations for the placement of the missiles, which were going to be shipped by sea. As this would be the first deployment in history of Soviet missiles outside the USSR, there were many issues to be discussed and resolved. For seven days Statsenko's people were advised on how to organize the movement of missiles by land